

Culture Unit (II)

人們打招呼的方式 — How Do People Greet Each Other?

Let's Learn Mandarin · Book 1

Illustration: A neighbor spots someone heading out the door and calls out “出去啊?(Chū qù a?) — Heading out?” Meanwhile, a friend passing by at 3 in the afternoon says “吃飽啦?(Chī bǎo la?) — Had enough to eat?”

Have you ever found it strange that when you leave for work in the morning, your neighbor sees you and asks “去上班啊?” (Off to work?) or “出去啊?” (Heading out?). Then at three in the afternoon you run into a friend and they ask “吃飽啦?” (Have you eaten your fill?). The answer is obvious — why would a friend or neighbor still need to ask? These phrases are simply a way that Chinese people say hello. You might wonder: when you first started learning Chinese, the very first thing your teacher taught you was “你好!” (Hello!) — so why don't they just say “你好!”? It's because close family members, friends, and neighbors in Chinese culture use this style of “asking the obvious” as a way of greeting.

In addition to “你好!” when meeting someone, it is also very common to hear things like “吃飽啦?” (Have you eaten your fill?), “吃飯啊?” (Having a meal?), “去上課啊?” (Off to class?), “回來啦!” (You're back!), and similar expressions. “你好!”, on the other hand, is typically used when meeting someone for the first time or in more formal settings. With this kind of greeting, you don't need to answer carefully or in detail — a simple response like “是啊!” (Yeah!) or “對啊!” (Right!) is perfectly fine. So in the future, if a Chinese person talks to you this way, don't be surprised — they're simply saying hello, just expressing that they're glad to see you.

Cultural Note: These casual, observational greetings — commenting on what someone is obviously doing — are a hallmark of warmth and familiarity in Chinese-speaking communities. They are not intrusive questions but friendly acknowledgments, the equivalent of a wave or a smile.